

World in Brief: America accuses China of evading tariffs; Israel removes settlers from West Bank



Photograph: Future Publishing via Getty Imag

The Trump administration accused China of evading **American tariffs** by rerouting exports through more than 40 countries. It estimates this costs up to \$26bn in lost annual tax revenue. It is developing an AI-powered “detective border” to catch tariff-dodgers. Meanwhile, in America’s other economic war, Scott Bessent, the treasury secretary, said the administration was preparing measures to punish **Iran’s** economy further.

America’s **Treasury** sold \$25bn-worth of 30-year **bonds** with yields of up to 5.22%, the highest they have been since 2001. Concern about America’s \$40trn debt and high inflation, partly caused by the Iran war, have been pushing yields higher across the board. On Wednesday \$42bn-worth of ten-year notes were sold at the highest yield since 2007.

Israeli troops launched a military operation to remove Israeli settlers from Qusra, a village in the **West Bank**. The **settlers** had besieged the homes of several Palestinian families and an American citizen, cutting off access to food, water and electricity. Mike Huckabee, America’s ambassador to Israel, condemned the settlers’ actions as a “horrific act of terror”. Taybeh, another West Bank

village, was closed to non-residents last week following similar attacks.

Nigel Farage [won](#) a by-election in Clacton that he triggered by resigning as the town's MP. The leader of Reform UK, a populist right-wing party, said victory would show he had popular support against "the establishment". Critics said it was to distract from scrutiny over an undeclared £5m (\$6.8m) gift. The major parties boycotted the election. His main opponent, a comedy character called Count Binface, won 9,455 votes to Mr Farage's 22,239.

NATO fighter jets shot down a **drone** over Latvia, the country's defence ministry said. It blamed the incursion on "Russian electromagnetic warfare", but did not say which country the drone belonged to. **Europe** is struggling to protect its airspace. Earlier this month a Russian drone [almost succeeded](#) in blowing up a Ukrainian transport plane parked in Leipzig-Halle Airport in Germany.

Wildfires broke out across Europe as the continent sweltered under another heatwave. Fanned by strong winds, fires set towns ablaze, forcing evacuations in Britain, France, Germany and Greece. One fire in Croatia left 36 people seriously injured. So far this summer wildfires have burned around 500,000 hectares of land in Europe; the continent is [warming faster](#) than any other.

South Korea's Incheon has overtaken Britain's Heathrow and Singapore's Changi as the **world's busiest airport** for international passengers. More than 38m people passed through the hub just outside Seoul in the first half of the year, the first time it has landed the top spot. Dubai fell out of the top five as the Iran war took a toll on passenger numbers.

Figure of the day: \$16bn, the annual sales that orexin medicines for sleep disorders could generate by 2035, according to Morgan

Stanley, a bank. [Read our story](#) about the new drugs regulating wakefulness.

A rain check for Europe's growth



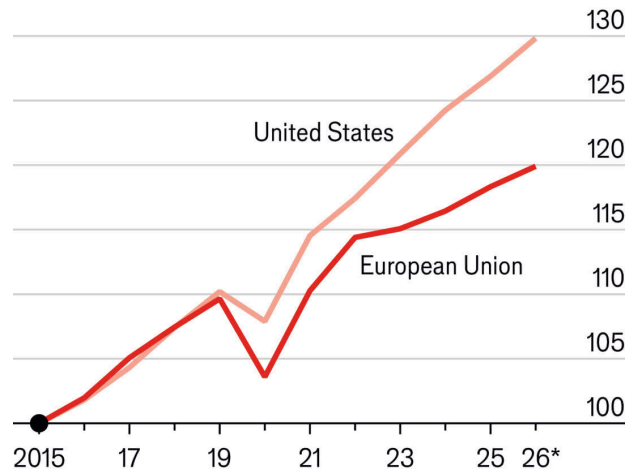
Photograph: Getty Images

The European Union publishes revised estimates of the bloc's second-quarter GDP on Friday alongside new employment data. A previous reading suggested that the euro area grew by 0.4% in the three months to June, and the entire EU's economy expanded by 0.5%.

Europe's recovery was already threatened by the war in Iran. Now the continent is suffering its fifth heatwave of the year. Triodos, a Dutch bank, has said that drought could wipe out much of the bloc's growth for the year. Poor harvests push up food prices; [drying rivers](#) disrupt shipping and power stations, which use the water for cooling. In France exceptional heat is expected to shave 1.4% off GDP this year, which could plunge the country into a recession. In the spring the European Commission had forecast annual growth of 0.9% for the euro zone and 1.1% for the EU. But that was before the rain stopped falling.

Running aground

GDP, 2015=100



Source: IMF

*Forecast

A twinkle of hope for Venezuelan democracy



Photograph: MIGUEL GUTIERREZ/EPA/Shutterstock

When American forces snatched Venezuela's dictator, Nicolás Maduro, in January, it was oil, not democracy, that seemed to be Donald Trump's priority. Yet [prospects for democracy](#) are improving. This week a first round of negotiations between Venezuela's regime and opposition figures ended with a modest agreement to begin a process of judicial reform, including of the Supreme Court.

Further talks may produce additional changes that could prepare the way for fair elections. [Expect intense negotiations](#) over who will sit on Venezuela's five-person electoral council and the Supreme Court. Negotiators will also discuss banned opposition politicians, guarantees for regime members who lose office and, on the margins, political prisoners. America has kept María Corina Machado, the main opposition leader, out of the talks, partly on the logic that if she is to run for president she should not be setting the rules. The next steps will be fiendishly difficult. American pressure on the regime will determine whether Venezuela has a good chance of returning to democracy.

Asics finds its stride



Photograph: Getty Images

In 1962 a pair of trainers caught the eye of Phil Knight, the future co-founder of Nike, while he was visiting Japan. He struck a deal with their maker, Kihachiro Onitsuka, to sell them in America. A decade later the pair fell out. After Mr Knight started Nike, Mr Kihachiro founded Asics. Today Nike is a global giant, but [is struggling](#) with falling sales as customers turn to more fashionable competitors. Asics, which reports second-quarter earnings on Friday, is one such.

The company keeps hitting [PBs](#). The first quarter of 2026 was its strongest yet: revenues rose by 30% year on year to \$1.7bn. A [running renaissance](#) has boosted sales of its pricey trainers; recently it has outsold Nike and Adidas, a German rival, when it comes to pairs costing over \$90. Onitsuka Tiger, Asics' fashion label, is growing, too, helped by a weak yen and a [tourism boom](#) in Japan. Across the industry, Asics is setting the pace.

A biopic with bite



Photograph: Seacia Pavao/A24

“I was—to be frank—a spoiled, miserable, narcissistic, self-destructive and thoughtless young lout, badly in need of a good ass-kicking,” wrote Anthony Bourdain in “Kitchen Confidential”, his memoir published in 2000. This confession opens “Tony”, a rollicking biopic of the late American chef’s formative years released in British cinemas on Friday (and in America on August 21st).

The film has plenty of bite. Dominic Sessa captures a teenage Bourdain’s swaggering yet sometimes self-conscious manner. And viewers experience the momentum of the chaotic kitchen where “the cooks *ruled*”, doing as much cocaine as cooking. The movie serves up plenty of actual bites, too: from lobster thermidor to clambake. “Tony” offers a small slice of Bourdain’s life and doesn’t mention his suicide in 2018. His former assistant reckons the chef would have objected to “the narrative’s sunny resolution”. After all, Bourdain saw that people, and kitchens, were fascinatingly messy.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: Which city is the site of the Truman Presidential Library?

Thursday: Which civil rights leader was baptised with the name of Michael, only to have his name changed by his father at the age of five?

*The aim of science is not to open
the door to infinite wisdom, but to
set some limit on infinite error.*

Bertolt Brecht